

Apple's wildly popular iPhone changed the smartphone market in many ways when it arrived in 2007. One of the most important iPhone innovations was placing the reins in Apple's hands when it came to controlling software updating, and not the wireless carriers. And the result has been years of steady improvements, all of them absolutely free, giving customers new and exciting capabilities over time. As a result, the iPhone has evolved into a truly compelling smartphone, one so influential that it has transformed the way other companies approach this market as well. Witness the rise of Google Android, a more open iPhone copy of sorts.

As for Microsoft, the software giant wanted to retain the good bits from Windows Mobile and throw out the bad. So while it still allows multiple device makers and wireless carriers to sell Windows Phones – diversity is good in some cases – it has also fleshed out a rigid set of hardware specifications for this platform. So if a device maker or wireless carrier wishes to sell Windows Phone devices, they must conform to the specs.

There were also a few other reasons Microsoft couldn't deliver software updates to Windows Mobile customers. Primarily, wireless carriers didn't want users to get free software updates and preferred customers purchase new phones for fairly obvious reasons.

What's on every Windows Phone

For now at least, these specs are liberating rather than confining, and at the time of Windows Phone's initial launch in late 2010, together they represent the makings of a very high-end smartphone indeed. According to Microsoft, every hardware producer using Windows Phone 7 must surely have the following specifications built into their device:

- ▶ **Processor (CPU):** All smartphones running on Windows Phones must have a minimum of 1 GHz ARMv7 Cortex or Scorpion processor. What this means to you is that all Windows Phone



Every Windows Phone mobile has to have certain hardware